

would be so excited by my lump sum that I would spend it immediately to cover my year of irresponsibility. My usual salary was too low so I'd spend all year putting off a lot of things I needed, like doctors' appointments or new boots. The lump sum paid for that. The flip side was that I wasn't saving, so if I didn't put down deductions on my W-2 initially, I was screwed come tax season if I needed to make any additional tax payments.

When I started working full time at BuzzFeed, a major corporation, I didn't know anything about filling out a W-2. I randomly claimed no deductions and turned in the form. I was too embarrassed to ask for help because it seemed like something I should already know. I figured if something was wrong, HR would just tell me to fill it out "correctly." Not so. Every couple of weeks, I was delighted by how much I was taking home. I eventually showed my coworker and then-boyfriend my paycheck. His eyes grew wide. We were making the same salary, but he was taking home much less. His expression said, "You're gonna be fucked on taxes." He was right. I owed \$700.

That's when I called the IRS, terrified, and asked about a payment plan. I don't love talking on the phone, especially with government employees. I worried the employee would laugh in my face and then drain my bank account and hold my cat as collateral for what I couldn't afford. The IRS sounded scary and evil. Why invite them into my life? In reality, the conversation was mundane. The IRS employee on the phone asked me what I thought I could reasonably pay each month and I meekly said, "Fifty dollars?" I was completely unsure if that was an okay number or if she'd yell at me for being a ne'er-do-well. The woman on the phone did not react at all. I was not the only person making this request. I probably wasn't even in the top 100 of people asking for small recurring payments. It was a comforting and depressing thought.

WHAT IS A W-9?

A W-9 is a tax form usually used by independent contractors. It's not one you turn into the IRS. You get it from your employers and they use it to keep track of your name, address, and taxpayer identification number after you turn it back in to them. The W-9 is used by the company to create your 1099 so they (and